

Midterm Exam Suggestion

Course: URIH-4701

Course Title: A Survey of Islamic History & Culture

Question 01: MOST IMPORTANT

Elucidate the concept of Khilafah in Islam. Explain the origin, development, and features of Khilafah in Islamic history. Mention the qualities, duties, and responsibilities of a Khalifah including the election system.

Answer:

In Islamic history, the term "Caliph" (Khalifah) connotes the representative of Allah on earth. The concept of Khilafah covers both the spiritual and temporal leadership of the Muslims, as the concept of separating the state from religion does not exist in Islam. The institution formally emerged in **632 AD** after the demise of the Prophet Muhammad (PBUH). The ultimate goal of the Khilafah is to uphold the Shari'ah and guide the Ummah (Muslim community) toward success in both this world and the hereafter.

Origin and Development of Khilafah

- **The Rightly Guided Caliphate (632–661 AD):** The institution originated at Saqifah Bani Saidah in **632 AD** with the *Khilafat ar-Rashida*. The Prophet (PBUH) did not establish a hereditary kingship, ensuring leadership was based on merit. This period included four caliphs: Hazrat Abu Bakr (**632–634 AD**), Hazrat Umar (**634–644 AD**), Hazrat Uthman (**644–656 AD**), and Hazrat Ali (**656–661 AD**).
- **Shift to Dynastic Rule (661–750 AD):** The democratic spirit of the early Khilafah changed during the Umayyad Caliphate (**661–750 AD**). Amir Muawiya nominated his son Yazid as his successor, which ended the practice of selection by consultation and transformed the Khilafah into a hereditary kingship.
- **The Abbasid and Ottoman Eras:** The Abbasid Caliphate inherited this dynastic model, ruling from Baghdad (**750–1258 AD**) and later Egypt (**1258–1517 AD**). Eventually, the Caliph became more of a figurehead. The institution continued under the Ottoman Caliphate from **1517 to 1924 AD**.

Features of Khilafah

- **Centralized Authority:** The Caliph was initially the supreme ruler of the entire Islamic world and its commander-in-chief.

- **Adherence to Shari'ah:** The fundamental feature of the Khilafah was its foundation on the Quran and the Sunnah of the Prophet (PBUH).
- **Administrative Simplicity to Complexity:** Early caliphates were marked by simplicity. Later, it evolved into a highly structured government with specialized departments, such as the *Diwanul Aziz* (Prime Minister's office) and *Qadiul Qudat* (Chief Justice).

Election System

- **Shura (Consultation):** Originally, the Caliph was selected through consultation. For example, Umar bin Khattab nominated a six-member Shura (council) to elect the next Caliph from among themselves.
- **Bay'at (Oath of Allegiance):** Once a Caliph was selected, the Muslims would give *bay'at* (the oath of allegiance) to legitimize his rule.
- **Nomination:** Later periods replaced consultation with the direct nomination of an heir-apparent (usually a son), followed by a mandatory public oath.

Qualities, Duties, and Responsibilities of a Khalifah

- **Qualities:** A Khalifah must be capable, pious, and rule like an "affectionate father of the Muslims" rather than a tyrant. He must take a pledge to strictly follow the Quran and the Prophet's traditions.
- **Duties and Responsibilities:**
 - **Defense and Expansion:** To be always ready for defense against enemies, command the armed forces, and protect the subjects.
 - **Law and Order:** To maintain peace in the territories, settle disputes, and implement equal justice for all.
 - **Administration:** To manage the treasury (*bait al-mal*), collect taxes justly, and appoint qualified governors, judges, and military commanders.
 - **Consultation:** To seek *Mashwara* (consultation) from religious scholars and legal experts in important matters.

The Khilafah is the central political and spiritual institution of Islamic history, originating in **632 AD**. Although its election system evolved from a merit-based consultative process during the period of the pious caliphs (**632–661 AD**) into a hereditary monarchy in later centuries, its primary purpose remained constant: to unite the Muslim world, protect the territories, and administer justice strictly according to the Quran and the Sunnah.

Question 02: MOST IMPORTANT

Investigate the causes of Riddah (Apostasy) War and point out the significant contributions of Khalifah Abu Bakr (R) as the savior of Islam.

Answer:

Hazrat Abu Bakr (R) was born in **573 A.D.**, accepted Islam in **610 A.D.**, migrated with the Prophet in **622 A.D.**, and ruled as the first Caliph from **632 to 634 A.D.** Following the demise of Prophet Muhammad (S.A.W.) in **632 A.D.**, a widespread rebellion broke out across the Arabian Peninsula against the religion of Islam and the newly established state of Madinah. Many tribes abandoned Islam, refused to pay Zakat, or followed false prophets. This movement is known as the Riddah (Apostasy) movement. During this extreme crisis, Hazrat Abu Bakr (R) played a crucial role in suppressing the rebellions, preserving the Muslim community, and earning the title "Saviour of Islam".

Causes of the Riddah (Apostasy) War

- **Limitations in Preaching and Lack of Genuine Faith:** Due to adverse communication and a short timeframe, the Prophet (S.A.W.) could not deeply establish Islam in all regions. Many tribes had accepted Islam merely for political alliance or for show, and lacking genuine faith, they reverted to their old religions after his death.
- **Opposition to Islamic Rules:** The strict moral discipline and structured lifestyle of Islam curtailed the personal liberties of the freedom-loving desert Bedouins, leading them to revolt.
- **Rejection of Madinah's Dominance:** Arabs were not accustomed to living under a central authority. The dismantling of their traditional tribal governance and jealousy over the dominance of Hejaz (Madinah) sparked rebellion.
- **Greed for Prophethood:** Witnessing the phenomenal political and religious success of the Prophet (S.A.W.), several impostors viewed prophethood as a profitable business. False prophets like Aswad Ansi (who captured Sana'a in **631 A.D.**), Musaylimah the Liar, Tulayha, and Sajah emerged and incited Arabs against Muslims.
- **Refusal to Pay Zakat:** Following the Prophet's death in **632 A.D.**, wealthy Bedouin tribes refused to pay Zakat, viewing it as an infringement on their freedom, and united under Tulayha to revolt against Madinah.
- **Instigation by Non-Muslims:** Jews who had been expelled from Madinah by the Prophet (S.A.W.) found an opportunity to provoke the Bedouins against Islamic principles.

Significant Contributions of Khalifah Abu Bakr (R) as the Savior of Islam

- **Saving the Caliphate:** After the Prophet's (S.A.W.) death in **632 A.D.**, severe disagreements arose regarding political succession. Abu Bakr (R) peacefully resolved the crisis at Saqifah Bani Sa'idah, preventing the total destruction of Islamic unity.
- **Checking the Apostasy Movement and Refusal of Zakat:** Realizing that failing to suppress apostasy would destroy Islam internally, Abu Bakr (R) took strict action. He rejected suggestions to temporarily exempt tribes from Zakat, firmly declaring they must pay or face war. He successfully defended Madinah from rebel attacks in the Battles of Rabadhah and Zul Qassah.
- **Suppression of False Prophets:** He divided his army into 11 divisions under experienced commanders like Khalid ibn al-Walid. Through decisive military campaigns, impostors were defeated; Tulayha and Sajah eventually embraced Islam, while Aswad Ansi and Musaylimah were killed. Musaylimah was defeated at the fierce Battle of Yamama (the "Garden of Death") in **633 A.D.**
- **Compilation of the Holy Quran:** During the Battle of Yamama in **633 A.D.**, many Hafiz (memorizers) of the Quran were martyred. Realizing the danger, Abu Bakr (R) accepted Hazrat Umar's (R) advice and formed a committee under Zayd ibn Thabit (R) to officially compile the Holy Quran into a single volume for preservation.
- **Expansion and Security of the State:** He not only protected Arabia from internal threats but also initiated campaigns against the hostile Persian and Byzantine Empires, securing victories like the Battle of Ajnadayn in **634 A.D.** to expand Muslim control.
- **Strengthening the Madinah State:** He governed as an epitome of democracy through the *Majlis-ash-Shura* and established the *Bayt al-Mal* to aid the poor, ensuring the state ran strictly on the Quran and Sunnah.

Historian Masudi correctly noted that without a caliph like Abu Bakr (R) after the Prophet's death in **632 A.D.**, the Islamic state could not have survived. Though his caliphate lasted only two years and three months, his firm faith, swift military actions against apostates (concluding around **633-634 A.D.**), and initiation of the Quran's compilation successfully consolidated the foundation of the Islamic empire.

Question 03:

Analyze the administrative development and reforms during the Khulafa-e-Rashidin period. How is modern administration indebted to these developments?

Answer:

The administrative framework during the Khulafa-e-Rashidin (the Rightly Guided Caliphs) period (632–661 AD) laid the foundation for the Islamic state based on the Quran, the Sunnah, and the principle of Shura (consultation). Unlike the autocratic empires of the time, the early caliphate (spanning these 29 years) was characterized by simplicity, equal justice, and a commitment to the welfare of the Ummah.

Administrative Developments during the Khulafa-e-Rashidin Period (632-661 AD)

- **Simplicity and Direct Access:** The administration did not demand a highly complex system; there were no formal posts for ministers or advisors. During emergencies, any capable individual could discharge advisory duties, and even an ordinary Bedouin had direct access to the Caliph.
- **Provincial Administration:** The Caliph divided the empire into provinces and appointed deputies (Governors or *Walis*) to rule over them. The primary functions of the governor were to maintain law and order, oversee defense against enemies, and collect taxes for the treasury.
- **Judicial System:** The Caliph appointed judges (*Qadis*) to promulgate Islamic laws, settle disputes, and ensure the people upheld Islamic conduct. The judge was generally not dependent upon the governor, ensuring an independent judiciary.
- **Financial Reforms:** To prevent corruption and ensure fair taxation, the Caliph sometimes appointed a separate tax collector alongside the judge and governor to strictly handle financial matters. The subjects were not unduly taxed, and grievances were redressed strictly in the light of Islamic law.

How Modern Administration is Indebted to These Developments

The core principles and basic divisions of labor established during the Rashidin period (632–661 AD) gradually evolved in later caliphates into specialized departments (*Diwans*) that heavily resemble modern bureaucratic administration:

- **Rule of Law and Equality:** The early Islamic justice system established that no one was above the law. In the *Darul Qada* (Judge's Court), even a powerful state governor could be sued and had to appear as an ordinary citizen to give proof, laying the groundwork for modern judicial equality.
- **Municipal and Market Regulation:** Modern city administration is indebted to the institution of the *Mohtasib*. Functioning exactly like a modern "municipal inspector," the Mohtasib patrolled the markets, prevented legal violations, and strictly checked the weights and measures of traders.

- **Postal and Intelligence Services:** Modern communication networks parallel the early *Sahebu Bareed* (Postmaster General) system. This department maintained lists of post offices, managed outposts, and gathered intelligence from all provinces to keep the central government informed.
- **Public Works and Engineering:** Modern state infrastructure departments reflect the early roles of the *Amirut Tamir* (Chief Architect) and *Diwanul Anhar* (Department of Canals). The state subsidized public works, often paying half the expenses for citizens who wanted to dig new agricultural canals to increase overall prosperity.

The Khulafa-e-Rashidin period (632–661 AD) established a transparent, decentralized, and justice-oriented administration. By separating executive, judicial, and financial powers, and prioritizing public welfare over royal pageantry, they planted the seeds for specialized departments (like municipal inspection, postal services, and public works) that form the backbone of modern administrative systems today.

Question 04:

Analyze the importance of Shura (Consultative System) and evaluate its development during the time of Prophet (SAAM) and the rightly-guided four pious Khalifah.

Answer:

In Islamic political theory, *Shura* (consultation) is a fundamental institution that forms the basis of democracy in Islam. It refers to the system of consultation with the people and among government officials for decision-making and selecting leaders. During the Rashidi Khilafah (632–661 AD), Shura was one of the most critical principles of governance, ensuring that authority was exercised through consent and mutual advice rather than autocratic rule.

Importance of Shura (Consultative System)

- **Basis of Democratic Governance:** Shura ensures that the government is established by the free choice and consent of the people, which is a core characteristic of the Islamic political system.
- **Prevention of Dictatorship and Monarchy:** The practice of Shura strictly distinguishes the *Khilafah* (Islamic Caliphate) from *Mulukiyyah* (hereditary kingship or monarchy). It ensures that leadership is not treated as a dynastic privilege but as a trust (*Amanah*) bestowed upon the most qualified individual.

- **Accountability and Justice:** Through Shura, the Khalifah remains accountable to the Muslim community and governs according to the Shari'ah, ensuring justice and public welfare.

Development of Shura During the Time of the Prophet (SAAM)

- The Prophet (SAAM) laid the foundational precedent for the consultative system by regularly seeking *Mashwara* (consultation) from his companions throughout his life.
- Most importantly, the Prophet (SAAM) did not publicly nominate a specific person as his political successor, nor did he establish a hereditary kingship before his death in **632 AD**. By doing so, he left the critical issue of future leadership entirely to the Shura and consensus of the Muslim Ummah.

Development of Shura During the Four Pious Khalifah (632–661 AD)

- **Hazrat Abu Bakr (RA):** The institution of Khilafah formally emerged through a critical Shura gathering at Saqifah Bani Saidah following the Prophet's death in **632 AD**. During a tense debate between the Ansar and Muhajirun, Abu Bakr (RA) used consultation and dialogue to prevent division, leading to his election. Throughout his caliphate, he actively governed the state through the *Majlis-ash-Shura* based on the Quran and Sunnah.
- **Hazrat Umar (RA):** Before his passing, Abu Bakr (RA) further developed the Shura process by widely consulting prominent Companions, including Abdur Rahman ibn Awf (RA) and Uthman (RA), to ensure that his nomination of Umar (RA) would be acceptable to the general Muslim community.
- **Hazrat Uthman (RA):** The Shura system reached a highly formalized stage when Umar (RA) established a specific Electoral Council (*Shura Council*) of six prominent Companions to elect the next Khalifah. Abdur Rahman ibn Awf (RA) consulted the council members individually, as well as the wider public, to determine that the majority opinion was in favor of Uthman (RA).
- **Hazrat Ali (RA):** Following the assassination of Uthman (RA) in **656 CE**, the state fell into severe political instability. Despite the chaos, Ali (RA) did not seize power by force; instead, he accepted the Caliphate in **656 CE** only after extensive consultation and the requests of the prominent citizens of Madinah and representatives from other provinces.

The Shura system is the lifeblood of early Islamic political administration. Initiated by the Prophet (SAAM) and practically formalized by the Khulafa-e-Rashidun between **632 AD and 661 AD**, Shura evolved from general mutual consultation into a sophisticated electoral process. This system

successfully prevented dynastic succession, preserved the solidarity of the Muslim Ummah, and established a truly democratic governance model in the early Islamic state.

Question 05: MOST IMPORTANT

Review the expansion of Islamic territories during the reign of Khalifah Umar (R). Discuss the conquest of Egypt and Jerusalem during the reign of Khalifah Umar (R).

Answer:

Hazrat Umar ibn al-Khattab (R) was the second Rightly Guided Caliph of Islam, ruling from **634 to 644 AD** after being nominated by Hazrat Abu Bakr (RA). His decade-long caliphate is regarded as the golden era of Islamic expansion, during which the borders of the Islamic state extended across the Persian and Byzantine (Roman) Empires. Madinah served as the central headquarters from where Caliph Umar actively directed campaigns, reviewed strategic maps, and administered new territories with exceptional justice and simplicity.

General Expansion of Islamic Territories (634–644 AD)

- **The Persian (Sassanid) Front:** Caliph Umar mobilized Muslim forces to dismantle the Sassanid Empire. Major confrontations included the Battle of al-Qadisiyyah (**636 AD**) led by Sa'd ibn Abi Waqqas, the Battle of Jalula (**637 AD**), and the decisive Battle of Nihawand (**642 AD**), known as the "Victory of Victories," which brought Iraq and the heartlands of Persia under Islamic rule.
- **The Syrian Front:** Muslim armies under the command of Abu Ubaydah ibn al-Jarrah and Khalid ibn al-Walid confronted the Byzantine forces. The decisive victory at the Battle of Yarmouk (**636 AD**) shattered Byzantine military power in the region, leading to the rapid fall of major Syrian cities including Damascus, Jordan, and Homs.

The Conquest of Jerusalem (Bait al-Maqdis) (637–638 AD)

- **Siege of the Holy City:** Following the triumph in Syria, Muslim armies advanced toward Jerusalem (Bait al-Maqdis) in **637 AD** and laid siege to the city under the leadership of Abu Ubaydah ibn al-Jarrah and Amr ibn al-Aas.
- **Conditions of Surrender:** Recognizing the futility of resistance, the Christian Patriarch Sophronius agreed to surrender the city peacefully, on the sole condition that Caliph Umar (R) travel to Jerusalem in person to sign the treaty and receive the keys of the city.
- **Umar's Journey and Simplicity:** In **637/638 AD**, Caliph Umar (R) traveled from Madinah to Bait al-Maqdis accompanied by only a single servant and one camel, alternating who rode and who led the mount. Upon his arrival, local commanders such as Amir Muawiya

welcomed him. Umar famously reprimanded commanders who adopted excessive royal grandeur, insisting on the austere principles of the early Caliphate.

- **The Treaty of Umar (Covenant of Jerusalem):** Umar (R) granted a historic covenant guaranteeing the Christian inhabitants absolute protection of their lives, property, churches, and complete freedom of religious practice without compulsion.
- **Respect for Sacred Sites:** Demonstrating profound tolerance, Caliph Umar declined an invitation to pray inside the Church of the Holy Sepulchre so that later generations of Muslims would not use it as a pretext to convert the church into a mosque. He subsequently cleared and designated the area of the Temple Mount (Masjid al-Aqsa) for Muslim prayer.

The Conquest of Egypt (639–642 AD)

- **Strategic Need:** Byzantine control over Egypt posed an ongoing naval and military threat to the Syrian coast and Hijaz. In **639 AD** (18 AH), General Amr ibn al-Aas secured permission from Caliph Umar to launch an expedition toward Egypt.
- **Early Engagements (640 AD):** Amr ibn al-Aas entered Egypt with an army of 4,000 men, capturing the frontier fortress of Pelusium (Al-Farama) and Bilbeis in **640 AD**.
- **Battle of Heliopolis and Fall of Babylon (640–641 AD):** Reinforced by troops led by Zubayr ibn al-Awwam, the Muslim army defeated the Byzantine forces at the Battle of Heliopolis (Ayn Shams) in **640 AD**. They subsequently besieged the formidable Byzantine stronghold, the Fortress of Babylon, which fell in April **641 AD**.
- **Capture of Alexandria (641–642 AD):** Muslim forces marched to Alexandria, the heavily fortified capital and chief naval base of Byzantine Egypt. Following a protracted siege, the Byzantine governor Cyrus signed a peace treaty in late **641 AD**, resulting in the complete evacuation of Byzantine troops in **642 AD**.
- **Establishment of Fustat:** Rather than residing in Alexandria, Amr ibn al-Aas founded the city of **Fustat** in **641 AD** as the new military and administrative capital of Islamic Egypt. The local Coptic Christian population was granted full religious freedom and relieved of heavy Byzantine taxation.

The caliphate of Hazrat Umar (R) (**634–644 AD**) successfully transformed the Islamic commonwealth into a world empire. The peaceful acquisition of Jerusalem and the strategic conquest of Egypt permanently eliminated Byzantine dominance in the Levant and North Africa. Caliph Umar's conquests remain unique in world history because they paired rapid military success with institutional justice, religious protection for conquered peoples, and unyielding administrative integrity.

Question 06:

Discuss the judicial system during the Khulafa-e-Rashidin period. Explain the development, features, and importance of the judicial administration during the period of the four pious Khalifah.

Answer:

During the Khulafa-e-Rashidin (Rightly Guided Caliphs) period (632–661 AD), the judicial system formed one of the most vital pillars of the Islamic state. Grounded strictly in the sovereignty of Allah, the Quran, and the Sunnah of the Prophet (SAW), the administration of justice was treated as a sacred trust (*Amanah*). The Khulafa-e-Rashidin established the foundational principles of the rule of law and an independent judiciary, ensuring that justice was administered equally without bias or executive interference.

Development of Judicial Administration (632–661 AD)

- **Hazrat Abu Bakr (RA) (632–634 AD):** In the earliest phase, the Caliph directly oversaw major legal disputes in Madinah while adhering strictly to the Quran and prophetic precedents. Prominent companions assisted him in offering legal opinions (*Ijtihad*).
- **Hazrat Umar (RA) (634–644 AD):** The judicial administration underwent institutionalization and separation from the executive. Caliph Umar formally separated the judiciary from the executive branch by appointing dedicated judges (*Qadis*) across the provinces, ensuring that the *Qadi* was not dependent upon the provincial governor (*Wali*). Four prominent figures recognized as leading *Qadis* and scholars of Fiqh during this era were Umar bin Khattab, Ali bin Abi Talib, Abdullah bin Masood, and Zaid bin Thabit.
- **Hazrat Uthman (RA) (644–656 AD) and Hazrat Ali (RA) (656–661 AD):** Both caliphs maintained this institutional independence. Hazrat Ali, renowned for his profound legal judgment and knowledge of the Quran and Sunnah, insisted on strict evidence and judicial impartiality, personally appearing in court without demanding royal privilege.

Features of the Rashidin Judicial System

- **Independence of the Judiciary:** A primary feature was the autonomy of the judge. The Caliph appointed the *Qadi* directly, and the provincial governor had no authority to overrule or dictate judicial verdicts.
- **Equality Before the Law (*Darul Qada*):** In the Judge's Court (*Darul Qada*), all individuals were treated equally regardless of social status or political power. If a citizen filed a suit against a state governor or the Caliph himself, the ruler had to appear in court as an ordinary citizen to present proof and submit to the court's decree.

- **Adherence to the Quran, Sunnah, and Ijtihad:** Judgments were derived directly from the Quran and the Sunnah. In instances where neither explicitly clarified a specific issue, qualified judges exercised *Ijtihad* (legal reasoning based on Islamic principles) through consultation (*Mashwara*).
- **Judicial Autonomy for Non-Muslims (*Dhimmis*):** To protect religious freedom, non-Muslim communities were granted legal autonomy. Judges from among themselves were appointed to settle their civil and personal disputes according to their own religious laws, though they also retained the right to seek justice in the *Darul Qada*.
- **Integrity and Witness Verification:** Judicial decisions relied strictly on authentic evidence and reliable testimony. Only individuals of upright moral standing and confirmed good character (*Adalah*) were permitted to give witness in court.

Importance of the Judicial Administration

- **Eradication of Tyranny and Oppression:** By subordinating executive rulers and military commanders to the Shari'ah, the system prevented autocratic abuse of power and corruption.
- **Public Peace and Prosperity:** Equal justice ensured that grievances were redressed promptly, creating a climate of security, mutual trust, and prosperity across the rapidly expanding Islamic empire.
- **Blueprint for Modern Legal Systems:** The Rashidin model established foundational modern judicial principles, including the formal separation of powers, judicial independence, the presumption of innocence, and the universal rule of law.

The judicial system during the Khulafa-e-Rashidin period (632–661 AD) established a legal administration centered on divine justice, moral integrity, and institutional independence. By separating the *Qadi* from the executive authority and enforcing absolute equality before the law, the four pious Caliphs created an enduring standard of justice that safeguarded the rights of all citizens and influenced administrative jurisprudence for centuries to follow.